
FM 506-E/3 · FIELD MANUAL · RESTRICTED
2 APRIL – 30 NOVEMBER 1945
EASY COMPANY
EUROPEAN WAR ROUTE
WWII • 1944 - 1945
EASY COMPANY IN
GERMANY & AUSTRIA
Company E · 506th Parachute Infantry · 101st Airborne Division
24 SITES · 5 DAYS · 21 POSITIONS
Free guide · dzcharlie.com · Printed edition of the phone guide. Positions carry a rating for how sure we are of the exact spot: HIGH (exact spot known), MEDIUM (right area), LOW (general area only).

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THE STORY IN BRIEF

This guide follows Company E, 506th Parachute Infantry, from the Rhine in April 1945 to the end of the division in November — Germany's collapse, the camps, Berchtesgaden and the occupation of Austria. Two sets of positions are kept apart on purpose:

TIMELINE — 21 historical positions in date order: what happened, where and when. **TOUR** — 20 stops in driving order across five days: where to go, for how long, and where to sleep. Every stop opens directly in Google Maps.

The Rhine — April 1945. Back from Haguenau, the 101st was decorated at Mourmelon and then sent not across the Rhine but to its west bank at Düsseldorf, to watch the Ruhr pocket. Easy held the dike at Stürzelberg for two weeks: boat patrols, a displaced-persons camp, passes to the rubble of Cologne. When the pocket surrendered on 18 April the division was released to the Seventh Army and started south along the autobahn.

Landsberg — the camp. On 28–29 April, near Landsberg, Easy Company entered one of the Kaufering sub-camps of Dachau — probably Kaufering IV at Hurlach, reached first by the 12th Armored Division the day before. Elements of the 101st arrived afterwards; alongside the 12th Armored, the division is recognised as a liberating unit by the US Army and the US Holocaust Memorial Museum. What they found: huts burned with the sick inside, the dead in the earth, the living too weak to stand. Winters ordered food; the medics had to stop the men eating it; Landsberg's citizens were marched out to bury the dead. Hitler killed himself the next day. Several Easy Company veterans later described the camp as one of their most disturbing experiences of the war.

Berchtesgaden — 5 May. Sent to occupy the mythical "Alpine Redoubt", the 506th was held at a blown bridge while the US 3rd Infantry and French 2nd Armoured Divisions got into Berchtesgaden first (who was first is still argued over); the 506th took over the town on 5 May. Sink took the Nazi Party's hotel; the men took the Obersalzberg — the burned Berghof, Göring's house and wine cellar, the Mercedes limousines — and Winters, Nixon and Welsh are said to have gone up to the Eagle's Nest, though that visit, the famous terrace photograph and who got there first (American or French troops) are all disputed. On VE Day, 8 May, the 506th was in the Berchtesgaden area.

Austria — Zell am See and Kaprun. The regiment moved into the Salzburg province to disarm the German army. Sink set up in the Grand Hotel on the lake at Zell am See; Easy was billeted at Kaprun, below a dam project built

partly with forced labour. Winters supervised the surrender and processing of German troops in the Saalfelden valley. Then a summer of road-blocks, swimming, hunting, points, and one shooting — Sgt. Grant, hit by a drunk replacement and saved by a German surgeon.

Joigny — the end. On 1 July the 506th left Austria for Joigny in France to train for the invasion of Japan. Japan surrendered on 15 August; the jump never came. The men went home by points through the autumn and the 101st Airborne Division was inactivated at Auxerre on 30 November 1945. Easy Company ceased to exist.

What it cost. Toccoa to Austria: 48 Easy men killed by the Winters/Ambrose count (other rosters and a US Senate resolution give 49, depending on whether a training death and attached men are included) and more than a hundred wounded. Of the 140 who jumped into Normandy, a couple of dozen were still with the company at Zell am See.

THE ACCURACY RULE

Museums, memorials, towns and the Eagle's Nest are exact. The Berchtesgadener Hof and Göring's house are documented sites that no longer exist — the pins mark where they stood. Where the record gives only a village, a convoy route or a valley, the entry is marked Area or Medium, and the pin is the centre of a search area.

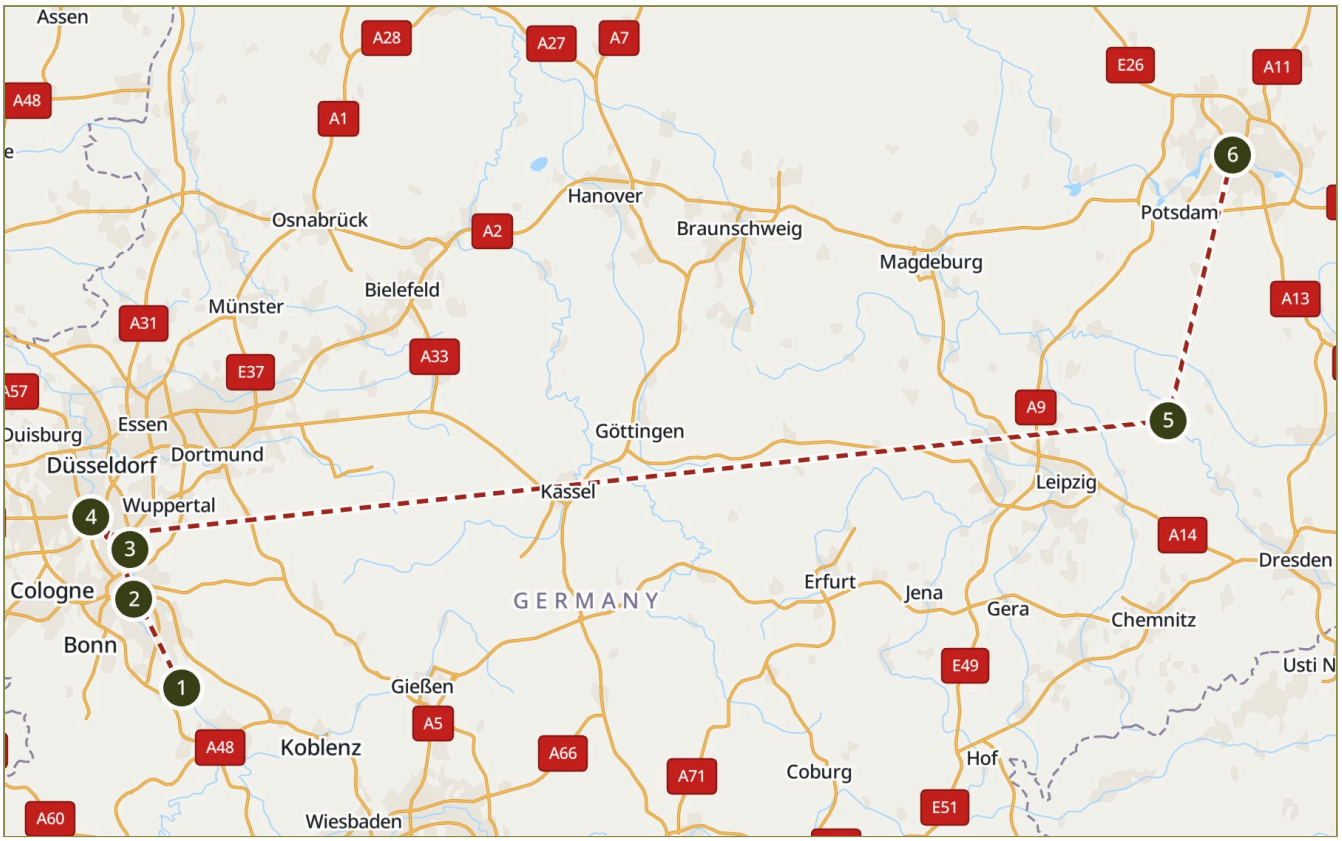
HIGH exact spot known — a landmark, museum, memorial or town MEDIUM well supported, but the exact spot is uncertain LOW general area only — the pin is the centre of a search area

HIGH exact spot known — a landmark, museum, memorial or town MEDIUM well supported, but the exact spot is uncertain LOW general area only — the pin is the centre of a search area

WHY THE WIDER TOUR

The full route adds Remagen, Dachau, the Munich and Nuremberg documentation centres and the Königssee, so that the company's last month sits inside the collapse of a state: the Rhine crossings, the camps, the Alpine Redoubt myth, the surrender at Reims.

DAY 1 — THE RHINE — REMAGEN TO STÜRZELBERG



1 Ludendorff Bridge, Remagen — Peace Museum
2 Cologne — cathedral and Hohenzollern bridge
3 Zons — the walled town on the Rhine
4 Stürzelberg — the Rhine dike
5 Torgau — Elbe Day
6 Berlin — Reichstag and the Führerbunker site

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

Remagen → Cologne → Zons → Stürzelberg · 4 stops

Where Easy first entered Germany: the bridge that opened the Rhine, the ruined cathedral city, and the quiet river dike the 506th watched for two weeks in April 1945.

1 Ludendorff Bridge, Remagen — Peace Museum

HIGH Bridge · 9th Armored, 7 March 1945 · ≈75 min

The railway bridge captured intact on 7 March that put the first Americans across the Rhine; it collapsed ten days later. The surviving towers hold the Peace Museum.

What you can see: Stand at the tower and look at the river's width — this was the wall the Allies expected to fight for.

Plan: Museum open Mar–Nov; check bruecke-remagen.de.

GPS 50.57900, 7.24250

2 Cologne — cathedral and Hohenzollern bridge

HIGH City · Timeline 3 · ≈90 min

The city 506th men saw on passes in April 1945: the cathedral standing over 90 % destruction. Climb the tower for the view the Americans had from the west bank.

What you can see: Compare the photographs in the NS Documentation Centre (EL-DE Haus, ten minutes' walk) with the square today.

Plan: Cathedral daily; EL-DE Haus Tue–Sun.

GPS 50.94130, 6.95830

3 Zons — the walled town on the Rhine

HIGH Town · 506th sector · ≈30 min

A medieval customs town on the 506th's stretch of river, untouched by the war, between Cologne and Dormagen. The dike path north of it is the regiment's April 1945 outpost line.

What you can see: Walk the dike north toward Stürzelberg.

GPS 51.12280, 6.84430

4 Stürzelberg — the Rhine dike

MEDIUM Timeline 2 · ≈30 min

The village on the river where the 2nd Battalion's HQ and Easy's outposts were, facing the Ruhr pocket across the water. Winters' patrols crossed here by boat.

What you can see: Stand on the dike: the far bank was Germany's last industrial fortress.

GPS 51.14135, 6.81650

5 Torgau — Elbe Day

HIGH D-Day · The Elbe · 25 April 1945 · ≈60 min

Where American and Soviet troops met and cut Germany in two.

What you can see: Memorial on the river; 4 h east of the route.

GPS 51.56000, 13.00500

6 Berlin — Reichstag and the Führerbunker site

HIGH D-Day · Berlin · 30 April – 2 May 1945 · ≈60 min

The end of Hitler and of the Reich; the bunker site is a car park with an information board.

What you can see: Far off the route; the Topography of Terror is nearby.

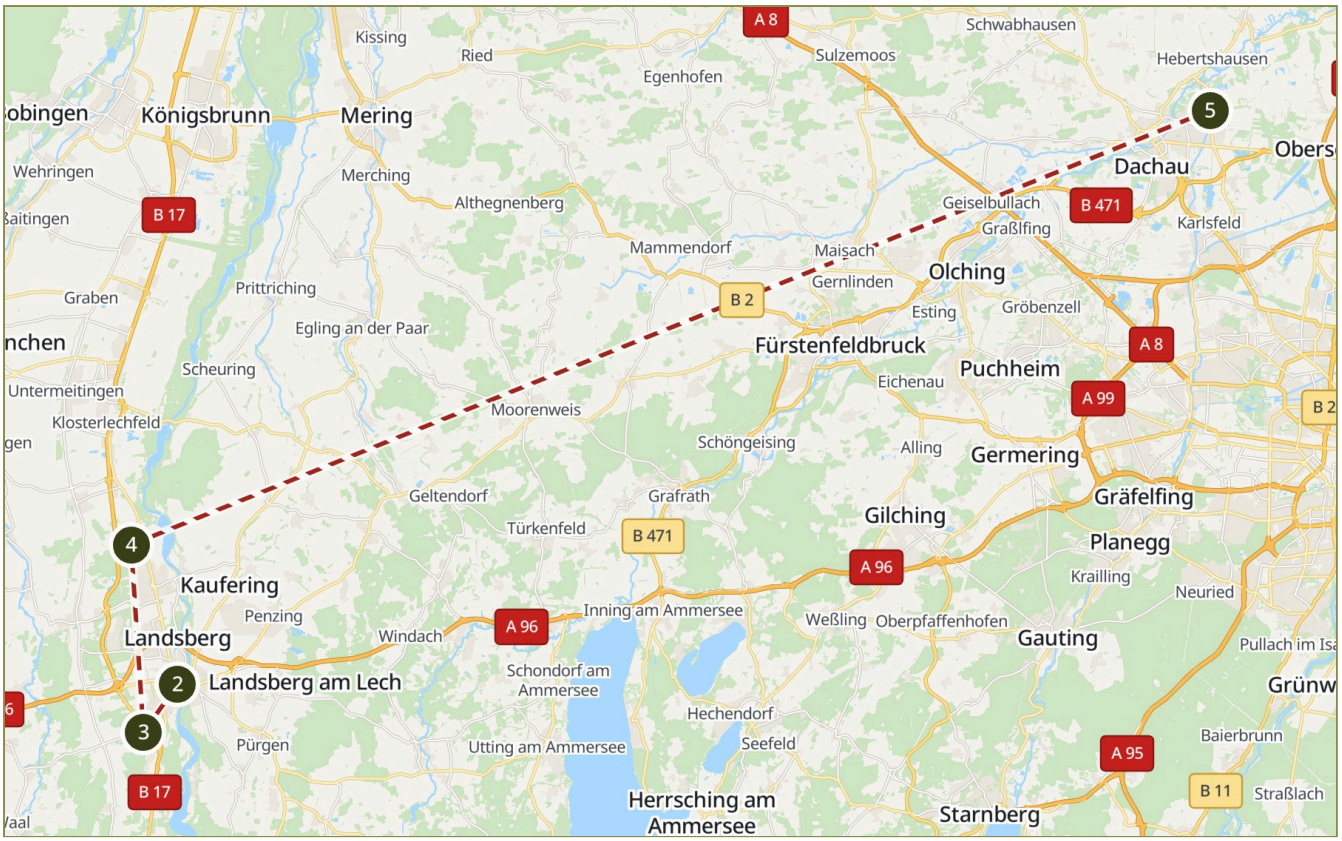
GPS 52.51270, 13.38110

End of day 1 — overnight: Cologne / Düsseldorf

Motorhome place, Cologne or Düsseldorf · Köln / Düsseldorf

City Reisemobilhafen sites on the Rhine in both cities — check park4night for the current one · GPS 50.94000, 6.96000

DAY 2 — BAVARIA — LANDSBERG AND THE CAMPS



2 Landsberg am Lech — old town and prison
3 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII
4 Hurlach — Kaufering IV camp site
5 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial
1 Nuremberg — Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld — off this map

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

Landsberg → Kaufering VII → Hurlach / Kaufering IV → Dachau · 4 stops

A long drive south (about 5.5 h from the Rhine), then the hardest day of the tour: the town where Hitler wrote Mein Kampf, the camp Easy found, and the camp that ran them all.

1 Nuremberg — Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld

HIGH D-Day · Bavaria · the rallies and the trials · ≈60 min

The party's parade ground and the courtroom of the 1945–46 trials.

What you can see: On the road south.

GPS 49.43350, 11.11080

2 Landsberg am Lech — old town and prison

HIGH Town · Timeline 9 · ≈45 min

Easy's billets from 30 April; the fortress prison above the town is where Hitler wrote Mein Kampf in 1924. The Lech weir and the painted old town are unchanged.

What you can see: Walk the Hauptplatz; look up to the prison on the hill.

GPS 48.04900, 10.87200

3 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII

HIGH Memorial · Timeline 8 · ≈60 min · ★ must see

The only Kaufering camp that survives: the earth huts, the foundations and the memorial stones of the nations whose citizens died in the eleven camps. 14,500 died here building underground factories.

What you can see: Place of remembrance first. Guided visits on set days; the outside is always accessible.

Plan: Erpftinger Strasse, Landsberg · check landsberger-zeitgeschichte.de.

`GPS 48.03048, 10.85248`

4 Hurlach — Kaufering IV camp site

HIGH Timeline 7 · ≈20 min · ★ must see

The camp usually identified as the one Easy Company entered on 28–29 April: the SS had set fire to the huts with the sick inside two days before. A memorial stone in the fields north of the village marks the site.

What you can see: Fields only; the stone is the marker.

`GPS 48.10280, 10.84520`

5 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial

HIGH Memorial · liberated 29 Apr 1945 · ≈150 min

The first camp and the model for all the others; the Kaufering camps were its sub-camps. Liberated by the 42nd and 45th Divisions the same weekend Easy was at Landsberg.

What you can see: Allow the full time. Free; audio guide recommended.

Plan: 09:00–17:00 daily · check kz-gedenkstaette-dachau.de.

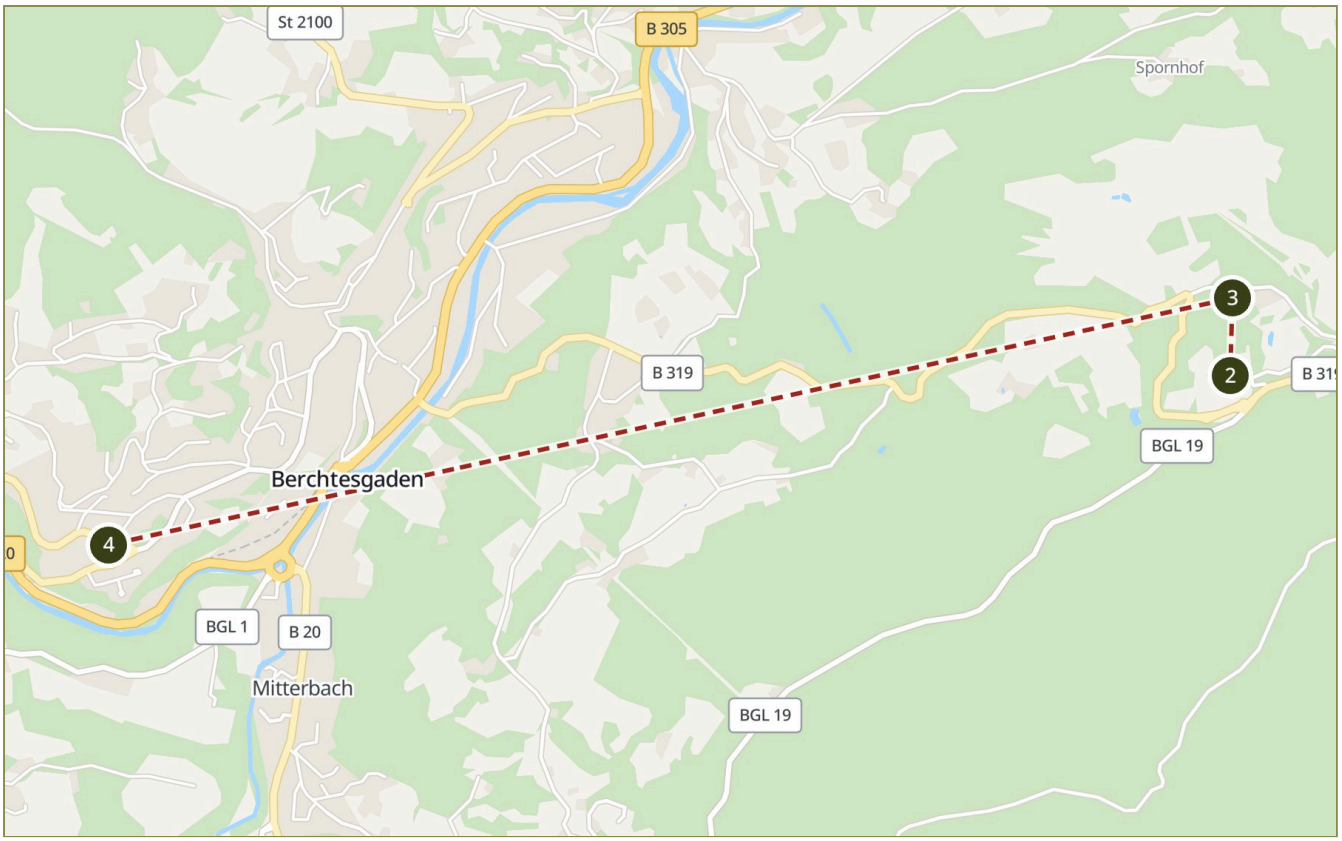
`GPS 48.26980, 11.46830`

End of day 2 — overnight: Dachau / Munich

Motorhome place, Dachau or Munich · Dachau / München

Several Reisemobil sites around Munich; check park4night · GPS 48.26000, 11.45000

DAY 3 — MUNICH TO THE OBERSALZBERG



2 Dokumentation Obersalzberg
3 Berghof site and the Obersalzberg walk
4 Berchtesgaden — town and the Berchtesgadener Hof site
1 Munich Documentation Centre for the History of National Socialism — off this map

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

Munich Documentation Centre → Dokumentation Obersalzberg → Berghof site → Berchtesgaden · 4 stops

From the birthplace of the Nazi Party to Hitler's mountain. Easy drove this road on 3–5 May 1945; you follow it with the museums that now explain what they found.

1 Munich Documentation Centre for the History of National Socialism

HIGH Museum · ≈90 min

On the site of the Brown House, the party's headquarters: how Munich made the movement, and what the city did with it. Context for everything on the Obersalzberg.

What you can see: Königsplatz outside was the parade ground.

Plan: Tue–Sun 10:00–19:00 · free.

GPS 48.14660, 11.56800

2 Dokumentation Obersalzberg

HIGH Museum · Timeline 13 · ≈120 min · ★ must see

The museum on Hitler's mountain: the Obersalzberg as the second seat of government, the bunker system underneath, and the American arrival of May 1945. Rebuilt and reopened in 2023.

What you can see: Go down into the bunkers — the 506th men did.

Plan: Apr–Oct 09:00–17:00, Nov–Mar Tue–Sun 10:00–15:00 · check obersalzberg.de.

GPS 47.63130, 13.04180

3 Berghof site and the Obersalzberg walk

HIGH Timeline 13 · ≈45 min · ★ must see

The foundations of Hitler's house, Göring's and Bormann's plots, the SS barracks site — mostly demolished in 1952, the rest cleared later, and forested. Signed paths from the Dokumentation centre.

What you can see: The retaining wall of the Berghof terrace is still there in the trees.

GPS 47.63360, 13.04190

4 Berchtesgaden — town and the Berchtesgadener Hof site

MEDIUM Timeline 12 & 15 · ≈30 min

The 506th's headquarters hotel stood in the town, near today's Haus der Berge national-park centre, until 2006; the old station built for Hitler's guests and the market square survive. VE Day found the 506th in this area.

What you can see: Walk the Maximilianstrasse; the hotel plot is now a park.

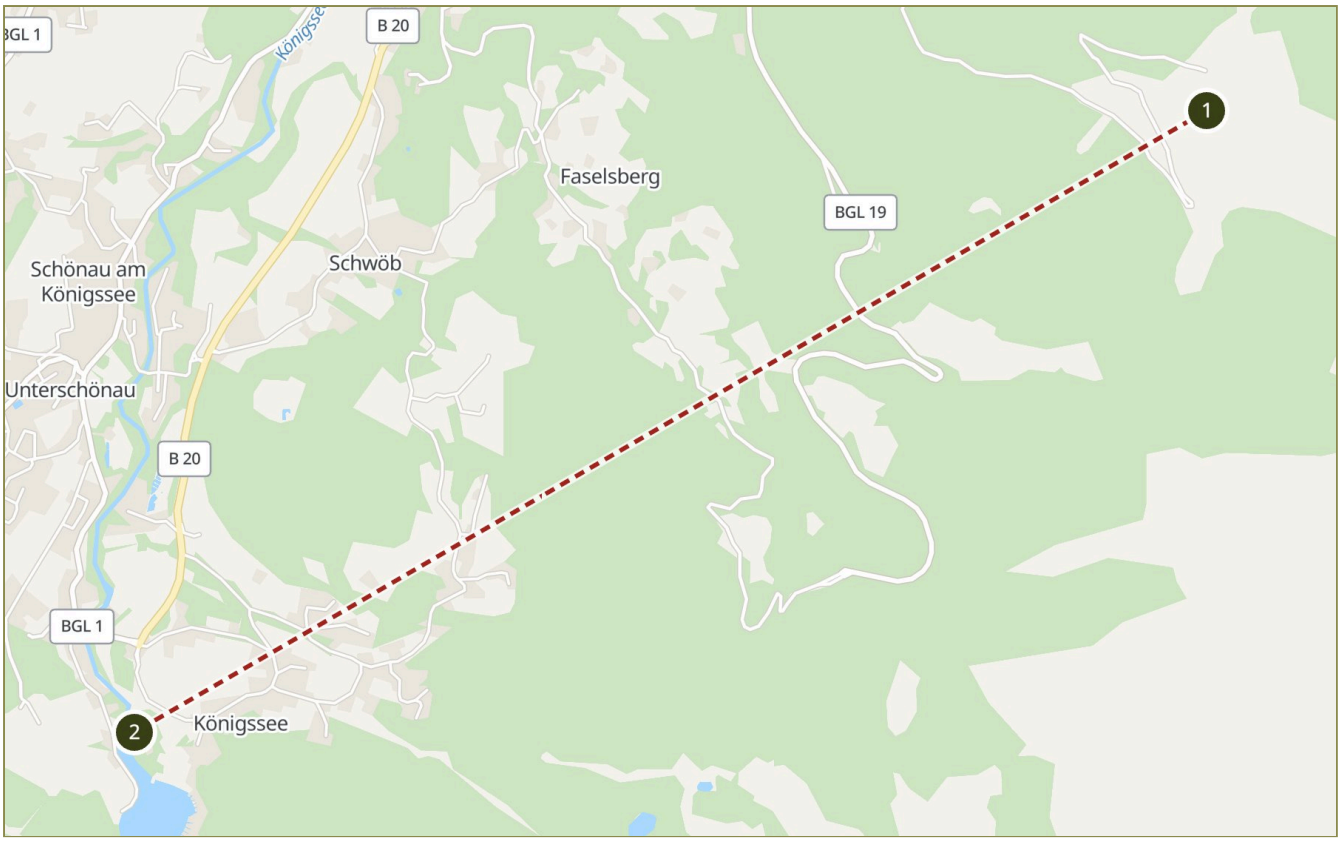
GPS 47.62630, 12.99250

End of day 3 — overnight: Berchtesgaden

Camping Allweglehen, Berchtesgaden · Allweggasse 4, 83471 Berchtesgaden

Terraced campsite above the town with motorhome pitches; verify season · GPS 47.64800, 13.03969

DAY 4 — THE EAGLE'S NEST AND THE KÖNIGSSEE



1 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest 2 Königssee 3 Bad Reichenhall — off this map

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

Kehlsteinhaus → Königssee → Bad Reichenhall · 3 stops

Up the mountain by the road Winters and Nixon drove, then the lake, then the valley mouth where the regiment was held up on 4 May.

1 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest

HIGH Site · Timeline 14 · ≈120 min · ★ must see

The tea-house at 1,834 m: the brass lift, the marble fireplace, the terrace traditionally identified as the setting of the famous Easy Company photograph (the exact location is disputed). Special buses from the Obersalzberg car park; no private cars.

What you can see: Stand on the terrace and turn to the Watzmann — same view, same railing.

Plan: Buses mid-May to Oct, 08:30–16:00 up · check kehlsteinhaus.de.

GPS 47.61140, 13.04180

2 Königssee

HIGH Lake · ≈120 min

The fjord-like lake below the Watzmann, where the 506th swam and boated in May 1945. Electric boats to St Bartholomä; the echo trumpet still plays.

What you can see: A rest from the museums.

Plan: Boats year-round, weather permitting.

GPS 47.59000, 12.98700

Read more: Wikipedia: Königssee

3 Bad Reichenhall

MEDIUM Timeline 11 · ≈30 min

The spa town at the valley mouth where the 506th's column waited at a blown bridge on 4 May while the 3rd Infantry Division and the French got into Berchtesgaden first.

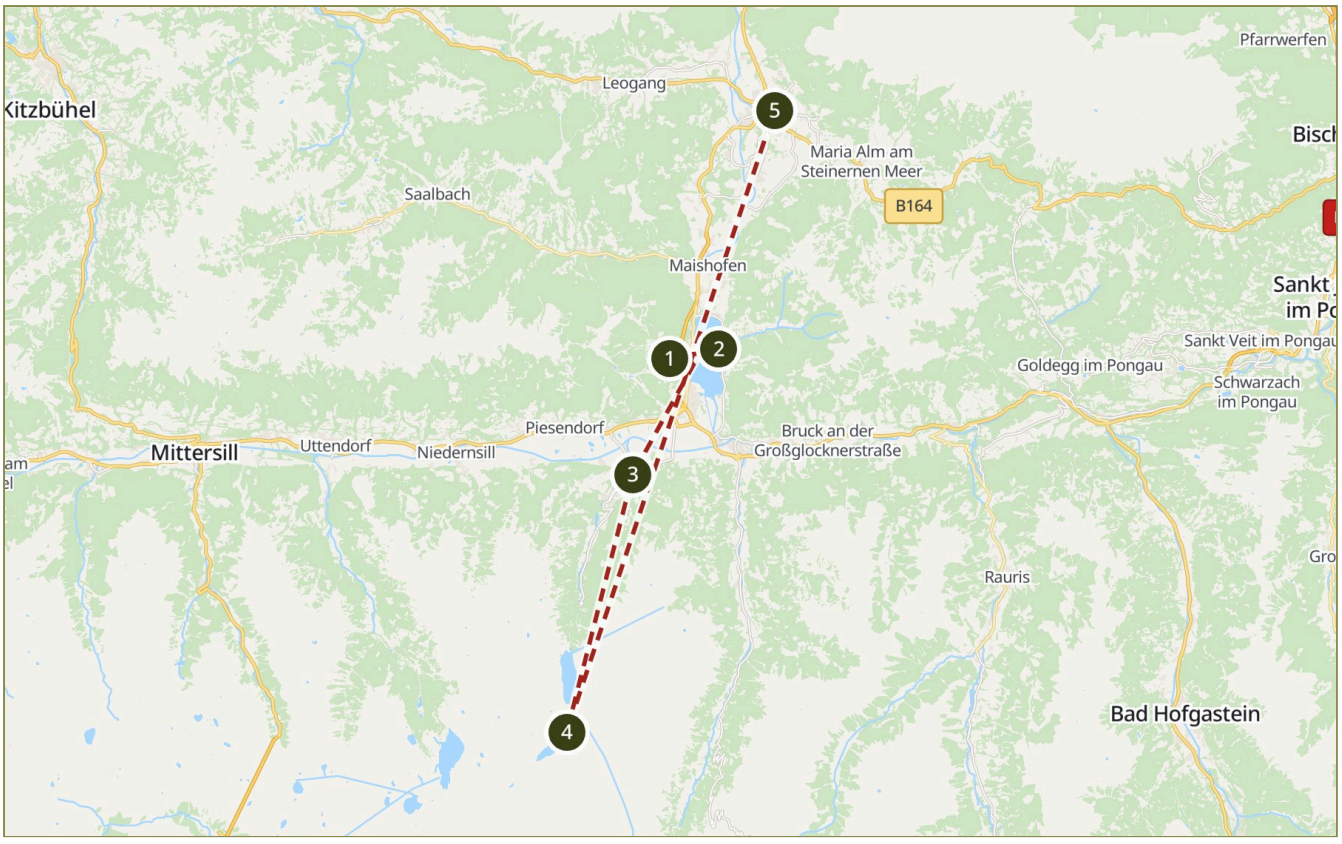
What you can see: The main road east toward the valley is the axis.

GPS 47.72450, 12.87700

Read more: Wikipedia: Berchtesgaden (1945)

End of day 4 — overnight: Berchtesgaden
Camping Allweglehen, Berchtesgaden · Allweggasse 4, 83471 Berchtesgaden
Second night; or move on to Zell am See (1 h) · GPS 47.64800, 13.03969

DAY 5 — AUSTRIA — ZELL AM SEE AND KAPRUN



1 Zell am See — lake promenade
2 Grand Hotel Zell am See — regimental HQ
3 Kaprun — village and castle
4 Kaprun high-mountain dams (Mooserboden)
5 Saalfelden — the surrender basin
6 Mauthausen Memorial — off this map

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

Zell am See → Grand Hotel → Kaprun → Kaprun dams → Saalfelden · 5 stops

Where the war ended for Easy Company: the lake, the hotel, the village billets, the dam site built partly with forced labour, and the valley where the German army surrendered.

1 Zell am See — lake promenade

HIGH Town · Timeline 16 & 19 · ≈30 min

The 506th's occupation capital in the summer of 1945. The lake is where the men swam and sailed Göring's yacht.

What you can see: Walk the Elisabeth promenade.

GPS 47.32310, 12.79400

2 Grand Hotel Zell am See — regimental HQ

HIGH Site · Timeline 16 · ≈30 min · ★ must see

Sink's headquarters on the promontory in the lake; the ballroom and terrace are as the regiment knew them. Still a hotel — coffee on the terrace is allowed.

What you can see: Look across to Thumersbach: the whole valley was the regiment's.

GPS 47.32405, 12.80120

3 Kaprun — village and castle

HIGH Village · Timeline 17 · ≈45 min · ★ must see

Easy's billets and the 2nd Battalion HQ, May–June 1945. Kaprun castle above the village; the church; the road-block where Sgt. Grant was shot was on the valley road.

What you can see: The village has grown around the ski trade; the castle and church are the anchors.

GPS 47.27230, 12.75900

4 Kaprun high-mountain dams (Mooserboden)

HIGH Site · slave-labour history · ≈120 min

The hydro-electric project begun in 1938 with forced and slave labour from the camps; the 506th guarded the site and its DP camp in 1945. Finished after the war as a symbol of Austrian reconstruction. Bus and inclined lift to the dams; exhibition "Erlebniswelt Strom".

What you can see: Read the memorial to the forced labourers at the dam.

Plan: Mid-May to Oct only; check verbund.com.

GPS 47.16250, 12.71750

5 Saalfelden — the surrender basin

MEDIUM Town · Timeline 18 · ≈30 min

The wide valley where German units marched in to surrender to the 506th in May 1945, and where a German surgeon saved Sgt. Grant's life.

What you can see: The Steinernes Meer above the town is the backdrop to the surrender photographs.

GPS 47.42700, 12.84800

6 Mauthausen Memorial

HIGH D-Day · Austria · the camps · 5 May 1945 · ≈60 min

The Austrian main camp, liberated the day Easy reached Berchtesgaden.

What you can see: 2 h east of Zell am See.

GPS 48.25700, 14.50100

End of day 5 — overnight: Zell am See

Seecamp Zell am See · Thumersbacher Strasse 34, 5700 Zell am See

Lakeside campsite with motorhome pitches; verify season · GPS 47.33966, 12.80912

THE TIMELINE



1 Mourmelon-le-Grand — Presidential Unit Citation
2 Stürzelberg / Dormagen — the Rhine bank
3 Cologne — the ruined city
4 Ruhr pocket surrenders — the front dissolves
5 The autobahn south — Württemberg
6 Buchloe / Landsberg sector — into Bavaria
7 Kaufering — the camp Easy found
8 Kaufering VII — European Holocaust Memorial
9 Landsberg am Lech — billets, and Hitler's prison
10 Munich — through the ruins
11 Bad Reichenhall — the blown bridge
12 Berchtesgaden — the Berchtesgadener Hof
13 Obersalzberg — the Berghof and Göring's house
14 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest
15 Berchtesgaden — VE Day
16 Zell am See — regimental HQ
17 Kaprun — 2nd Battalion and Easy Company
18 Saalfelden — the German surrender
19 Zell am See — the summer of 1945
20 Joigny — the barracks in France
21 Auxerre — the 101st Airborne inactivated

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

21 historical positions in date order: what happened, where and when. The numbers follow the company's movement.

1 Mourmelon-le-Grand — Presidential Unit Citation

LOW 25 Feb – 1 Apr 1945 · Rhineland

Back from Haguenau by boxcar. On 15 March Eisenhower reviewed the 101st and presented the first Presidential Unit Citation ever given to an entire division, for Bastogne. Replacements arrived; the veterans watched the Rhine crossings on the newsreels and wondered whether they would jump again.

On the ground: Outside the map area: the Champagne garrison town near Reims. Included to open the sequence.

GPS 49.14010, 4.36580

2 Stürzelberg / Dormagen — the Rhine bank

MEDIUM 2–18 Apr 1945 · Rhineland

The 101st was sent to the west bank of the Rhine south of Düsseldorf to face the Ruhr pocket. The 506th held the river line around Stürzelberg and Dormagen: outposts on the dike, a displaced-persons camp to guard, patrols by boat across the water. Winters' battalion HQ was in a village house on the river. Easy's first sight of Germany was a country of white flags.

On the ground: The river dike at Stürzelberg is the reference; the exact billets are not recorded.

GPS 51.14135, 6.81650

3 Cologne — the ruined city

MEDIUM April 1945 · Rhineland

Men of the 506th went into Cologne on passes: the cathedral standing in a sea of rubble, the Hohenzollern bridge in the river. For most it was the first German city they had seen and the first proof of what the bombing had done.

On the ground: The cathedral square; the rebuilt bridge beside it.

GPS 50.94130, 6.95830

4 Ruhr pocket surrenders — the front dissolves

LOW 18 Apr 1945 · Rhineland

The 317,000 Germans trapped in the Ruhr gave up on 18 April. The 101st's Rhine mission ended; the division was transferred to the Seventh Army for the drive into Bavaria and the supposed 'Alpine Redoubt'.

On the ground: Area reference for the whole Rhine sector.

GPS 51.20000, 6.80000

5 The autobahn south — Württemberg

LOW 22–26 Apr 1945 · Bavaria & the camps

By truck and DUKW down the autobahn through the Rhineland and Württemberg, past columns of surrendering Germans and liberated slave labourers walking the other way. Ulm's cathedral was the landmark. Nobody shot at them.

On the ground: Chronological reference only — the convoy route is not documented in detail.

GPS 48.40000, 9.99000

6 Buchloe / Landsberg sector — into Bavaria

MEDIUM 27–28 Apr 1945 · Bavaria & the camps

The 506th came into the Landsberg area behind the 12th Armored and 4th Infantry Divisions. The country looked untouched; then the smell reached them.

On the ground: Buchloe, west of Landsberg, is the reference for the regiment's approach.

GPS 48.03800, 10.72500

7 Kaufering — the camp Easy found

HIGH 28–29 Apr 1945 · Bavaria & the camps

Easy Company entered one of the Kaufering sub-camps of Dachau — usually identified as Kaufering IV at Hurlach, reached by the 12th Armored Division on 27 April, a day before the 101st arrived; the SS had burned the huts with the sick inside two days earlier. Typhus, starvation, the dead in the earth huts. Winters ordered food brought in; the medics then had to stop the men eating; Landsberg's citizens were marched out to bury the dead. Several Easy Company veterans later described the camp as one of their most disturbing experiences of the war.

On the ground: Fields between Hurlach and Kaufering; a memorial stone stands where Camp IV was. The preserved earth huts are at Camp VII, south of Landsberg.

GPS 48.10280, 10.84520

8 Kaufering VII — European Holocaust Memorial

HIGH 29–30 Apr 1945 · Bavaria & the camps

The one Kaufering camp that survives: earth huts, foundations and the memorial stones of the nations whose people died here. 30,000 Jews passed through the eleven Kaufering camps building underground aircraft factories; 14,500 died.

On the ground: Erpftinger Strasse, south of Landsberg. Place of remembrance.

GPS 48.03048, 10.85248

9 Landsberg am Lech — billets, and Hitler's prison

HIGH 30 Apr – 2 May 1945 · Bavaria & the camps

The company was billeted in the town where Hitler had written Mein Kampf in the fortress prison in 1924. On 30 April the news came that he was dead in Berlin. Sink set up in the town; the men were made to see the camp.

On the ground: The old town on the Lech; the prison stands on the hill above.

GPS 48.04900, 10.87200

10 Munich — through the ruins

LOW 3 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

The convoy passed through Munich, taken by the Seventh Army on 30 April, on the autobahn toward the Alps. The 'capital of the movement' was a shell.

On the ground: Area reference: the autobahn ring, not the city centre.

GPS 48.13720, 11.57550

11 Bad Reichenhall — the blown bridge

MEDIUM 4 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

The 506th's column was held up by a demolished bridge on the road into the Berchtesgaden valley while the US 3rd Infantry Division and the French 2nd Armoured got into the town first. Sink was not pleased.

On the ground: The spa town at the mouth of the valley; the bridge site is on the main road east.

GPS 47.72450, 12.87700

12 Berchtesgaden — the Berchtesgadener Hof

MEDIUM 5 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

The 506th entered Berchtesgaden on the afternoon of 5 May. Sink took the Berchtesgadener Hof, the Nazi Party's grand hotel, as regimental HQ; Winters' 2nd Battalion set up there too, and the men found the wine cellars, the silver and the Mercedes limousines. The hotel was demolished in 2006; its site in the town, near today's Haus der Berge national-park centre, is several kilometres below the Obersalzberg.

On the ground: Site only; the town centre and the old railway station (built for Hitler's guests) survive.

GPS 47.62630, 12.99250

13 Obersalzberg — the Berghof and Göring's house

HIGH 5–7 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

Hitler's mountain: the Berghof, bombed by the RAF on 25 April and burned by the SS, Göring's and Bormann's houses, the SS barracks, the tunnel system. Easy men walked through the ruins and helped themselves to what was left; Göring's wine cellar became legend. Most of the major Nazi structures were demolished in 1952 or removed in later phases; the Dokumentation Obersalzberg now stands on the site.

On the ground: The Berghof foundations are a short walk from the Dokumentation centre; the bunkers are inside it.

GPS 47.63360, 13.04190

14 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest

HIGH 5–6 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

The tea-house on the Kehlstein, 1,834 m up, built for Hitler's 50th birthday. Winters, Nixon, Welsh and Easy men are said to have gone up after 5 May (who got there first is disputed); the photograph of them on a terrace, traditionally identified as the Eagle's Nest though some researchers place it at another Obersalzberg property, is the end of the Easy Company war in one frame. Whether they used the brass lift is uncertain — it had reportedly been disabled when the first troops arrived. The house survived because the RAF missed it.

On the ground: Buses from Obersalzberg mid-May to October; the lift and the terrace are as they were.

GPS 47.61140, 13.04180

15 Berchtesgaden — VE Day

HIGH 8 May 1945 · Berchtesgaden

The war in Europe ended with the 506th around Berchtesgaden. Winters' order for the day — 'effective immediately, all troops will stand fast' — and the champagne from Göring's cellar. The men began counting points.

On the ground: Town centre.

GPS 47.62960, 13.00300

16 Zell am See — regimental HQ

HIGH 9 May – Jun 1945 · Austria

The 506th moved over the border into the Austrian Salzburg province to disarm the German forces there. Sink's regimental HQ was in the Grand Hotel on the lake at Zell am See; the town became the regiment's occupation capital for the summer.

On the ground: The Grand Hotel still stands on the promontory in the lake.

GPS 47.32310, 12.79400

17 Kaprun — 2nd Battalion and Easy Company

HIGH May – Jun 1945 · Austria

Easy was billeted in Kaprun, at the foot of the Glockner range, with the battalion HQ. Occupation duty: road-blocks, collecting weapons, guarding the vast dam construction site with its slave-labour camp, and a great deal of swimming, hunting and drinking. The Sergeant Grant shooting is usually placed at a road-block in this area; the exact spot, like the company's billets, is not documented.

On the ground: The village and castle; the dams above are the post-war continuation of the Nazi-era project.

GPS 47.27230, 12.75900

18 Saalfelden — the German surrender

MEDIUM May 1945 · Austria

Winters supervised the surrender of German units in the valley — columns marching in with their weapons, ordered to stack them and go home. Which formation and which commander is not recorded in a primary source. Tens of thousands of German soldiers were processed through the Saalfelden–Zell basin. Here, too, a German brain surgeon saved Sergeant Grant's life.

On the ground: Market town north of Zell am See; area reference for the surrender fields.

GPS 47.42700, 12.84800

19 Zell am See — the summer of 1945

LOW Jun – 30 Jun 1945 · Austria

Training for the Pacific began again in June — the 101st was scheduled to jump on Japan. Men with 85 points went home; the rest swam in the lake, drove Göring's cars and waited. On 1 July the regiment left Austria.

On the ground: Area reference: the lake and the valley.

GPS 47.30000, 12.80000

20 Joigny — the barracks in France

HIGH Jul – Nov 1945 · Home

The 101st was reassembled in the Yonne, at Joigny and Auxerre, to reorganise for the Pacific. Japan surrendered on 15 August and the jump never came. The company emptied by points through the autumn; Winters, Welsh, Speirs and the last of the Toccoa men went home one by one.

On the ground: Outside the map area; included to close the sequence.

GPS 47.98250, 3.39860

21 Auxerre — the 101st Airborne inactivated

HIGH 30 Nov 1945 · Home

On 30 November 1945 the 101st Airborne Division was inactivated in France and Easy Company ceased to exist. Of the 140 men who had jumped into Normandy, and the hundreds who followed, 48 Easy men had been killed by the Winters/Ambrose count — 49 by other rosters. The company's flag went home in a footlocker.

On the ground: Outside the map area; the end of the story.

GPS 47.79820, 3.56750

THE END OF THE REICH — THE WIDER WAR



1 Ludendorff Bridge, Remagen — Peace Museum

2 Cologne — cathedral and Hohenzollern bridge

3 Stürzelberg — the Rhine dike

4 Torgau — Elbe Day

5 Berlin — Reichstag and the Führerbunker site

6 Nuremberg — Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld

7 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII

8 Hurlach — Kaufering IV camp site

9 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial

10 Landsberg am Lech — old town and prison

11 Munich Documentation Centre for the History of National Socialism

12 Dokumentation Obersalzberg

13 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest

14 Berchtesgaden — town and the Berchtesgadener Hof site

15 Grand Hotel Zell am See — regimental HQ

16 Kaprun — village and castle

17 Saalfelden — the surrender basin

18 Mauthausen Memorial

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

THE DECISIVE FACTORS

Crossing the Rhine. The last great barrier. The Ludendorff bridge at Remagen fell intact to the 9th Armored on 7 March; Patton crossed at Oppenheim on the 22nd; Montgomery's set-piece with the airborne drop of Operation Varsity came on the 24th. The 101st was not used — Easy watched it on the newsreels at Mourmelon and was sent to the west bank of the river at Düsseldorf on 2 April instead. 7 Mar Remagen · 22 Mar Oppenheim · 24 Mar Varsity (17th Airborne, 6th Airborne)

The Ruhr pocket. Two American armies met at Lippstadt on 1 April and trapped Army Group B — 317,000 men — in Germany's industrial heart. The 101st held the Rhine bank on the pocket's western edge while it was squeezed from the east; it surrendered on 18 April and Field Marshal Model shot himself. The war in the west was decided; what remained was distance. 1–18 Apr 1945 · 317,000 prisoners · Easy on the Rhine dike at Stürzelberg

The camps. Ohrdruf on 4 April, Buchenwald on the 11th, Bergen-Belsen on the 15th, the Kaufering camps from the 27th, Dachau on the 29th. Every division that reached Bavaria found one. Easy Company's was a Kaufering sub-camp near Landsberg — burned huts, typhus, the living too weak to stand. Eisenhower ordered German civilians marched through them; Landsberg's were made to bury the dead. Kaufering: 11 camps · ≈30,000 prisoners · ≈14,500 dead

The Alpine Redoubt. Allied intelligence believed the Nazis would make a last stand in the Alps around Berchtesgaden. It did not exist, but the fear of it helped send the Seventh Army — and the 101st — south into Bavaria within the agreed Allied zones, and gave Easy Company its last objective: Hitler's mountain. Why the 101st went to Berchtesgaden and not to Berlin

The race for Berchtesgaden. The RAF bombed the Obersalzberg on 25 April; the SS burned the Berghof on 4 May. The US 3rd Infantry Division and the French 2nd Armoured got into the town on 4 May; the 506th, held at a blown bridge near Bad Reichenhall, arrived on the 5th and took over. Who got there first mattered enormously to Sink and to no one else. 4–5 May 1945 · 3rd ID, 2e DB, then the 101st

The end of the Reich. Hitler shot himself in Berlin on 30 April; Berlin surrendered on 2 May; German forces in Italy the same day, in the north-west on the 4th. Jodl signed the unconditional surrender at Eisenhower's HQ in Reims at 02:41 on 7 May, repeated for the Soviets at Karlshorst on the 8th. VE Day found the 506th around Berchtesgaden, with Göring's wine. 30 Apr – 8 May 1945

Occupation and the points system. Disarming the Wehrmacht, guarding displaced persons, road-blocks, looting and boredom. Every man had a score — points for months overseas, campaigns, decorations, children — and 85 sent you home. The veterans left one by one through the summer; the replacements trained for the invasion of Japan. Discipline frayed: Sgt. Grant was shot by a drunk replacement at a road-block in June. 85 points = home · 101st slated for the Pacific

Japan surrenders — the jump that never came. The atomic bombs on 6 and 9 August and Japan's surrender on 15 August ended the Pacific plan. The 101st, at Joigny in France since July, had nothing left to do but send its men home. It was inactivated at Auxerre on 30 November 1945. 15 Aug 1945 · 30 Nov 1945 inactivation

The cost of Easy Company's war. From Toccoa to Austria the company took roughly 150 % casualties: about 48 men killed and more than 100 wounded, many of them more than once. Of the 140 who jumped on 6 June 1944, a couple of dozen were still with the company in Austria. The memorials on this route — Kaufering, Dachau, the Obersalzberg — are the reason they said it was worth it. 48–49 Easy men killed, June 1944 – May 1945 (count varies by roster)

KEY SITES OF THE WAR'S END

1 Ludendorff Bridge, Remagen — Peace Museum

HIGH The Rhine · 7 March 1945

The bridge that opened the Rhine.

What you can see: Peace Museum in the towers.

GPS 50.57900, 7.24250

2 Cologne — cathedral and Hohenzollern bridge

HIGH The Rhine · ruined city

The cathedral over 90 % destruction.

What you can see: City centre.

GPS 50.94130, 6.95830

3 Stürzelberg — the Rhine dike

HIGH The Ruhr pocket · Easy Company

The 506th's April 1945 river line.

What you can see: Dike path.

GPS 51.14135, 6.81650

4 Torgau — Elbe Day

HIGH The Elbe · 25 April 1945

Where American and Soviet troops met and cut Germany in two.

What you can see: Memorial on the river; 4 h east of the route.

GPS 51.56000, 13.00500

5 Berlin — Reichstag and the Führerbunker site

HIGH Berlin · 30 April – 2 May 1945

The end of Hitler and of the Reich; the bunker site is a car park with an information board.

What you can see: Far off the route; the Topography of Terror is nearby.

GPS 52.51270, 13.38110

6 Nuremberg — Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld

HIGH Bavaria · the rallies and the trials

The party's parade ground and the courtroom of the 1945–46 trials.

What you can see: On the road south.

GPS 49.43350, 11.11080

7 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII

HIGH Bavaria · the camps · Easy Company

The surviving Kaufering camp.

What you can see: Landsberg.

GPS 48.03048, 10.85248

8 Hurlach — Kaufering IV camp site

HIGH Bavaria · the camps · Easy Company

The camp Easy found.

What you can see: Fields; memorial stone.

GPS 48.10280, 10.84520

9 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial

HIGH Bavaria · the camps

The first camp; liberated 29 April.

What you can see: Memorial site.

GPS 48.26980, 11.46830

10 Landsberg am Lech — old town and prison

HIGH Bavaria · Easy Company billets

Hitler's prison; Easy's town on 30 April.

What you can see: Old town.

GPS 48.04900, 10.87200

11 Munich Documentation Centre for the History of National Socialism

HIGH Bavaria · birthplace of the party

How Munich made the movement.

What you can see: Königsplatz.

GPS 48.14660, 11.56800

12 Dokumentation Obersalzberg

HIGH Berchtesgaden · Hitler's mountain

The museum and bunkers on the site.

What you can see: Obersalzberg.

GPS 47.63130, 13.04180

13 Kehlsteinhaus — the Eagle's Nest

HIGH Berchtesgaden · Easy Company

The terrace of the photograph.

What you can see: Bus from Obersalzberg.

GPS 47.61140, 13.04180

14 Berchtesgaden — town and the Berchtesgadener Hof site

HIGH Berchtesgaden · VE Day

Where the war ended for Easy.

What you can see: Town.

GPS 47.62630, 12.99250

15 Grand Hotel Zell am See — regimental HQ

HIGH Austria · occupation

Sink's HQ on the lake.

What you can see: Hotel terrace.

GPS 47.32405, 12.80120

16 Kaprun — village and castle

HIGH Austria · Easy Company billets

Easy's last billets.

What you can see: Village.

GPS 47.27230, 12.75900

17 Saalfelden — the surrender basin

HIGH Austria · the German surrender

Where the Wehrmacht marched in to surrender.

What you can see: Valley.

GPS 47.42700, 12.84800

18 Mauthausen Memorial

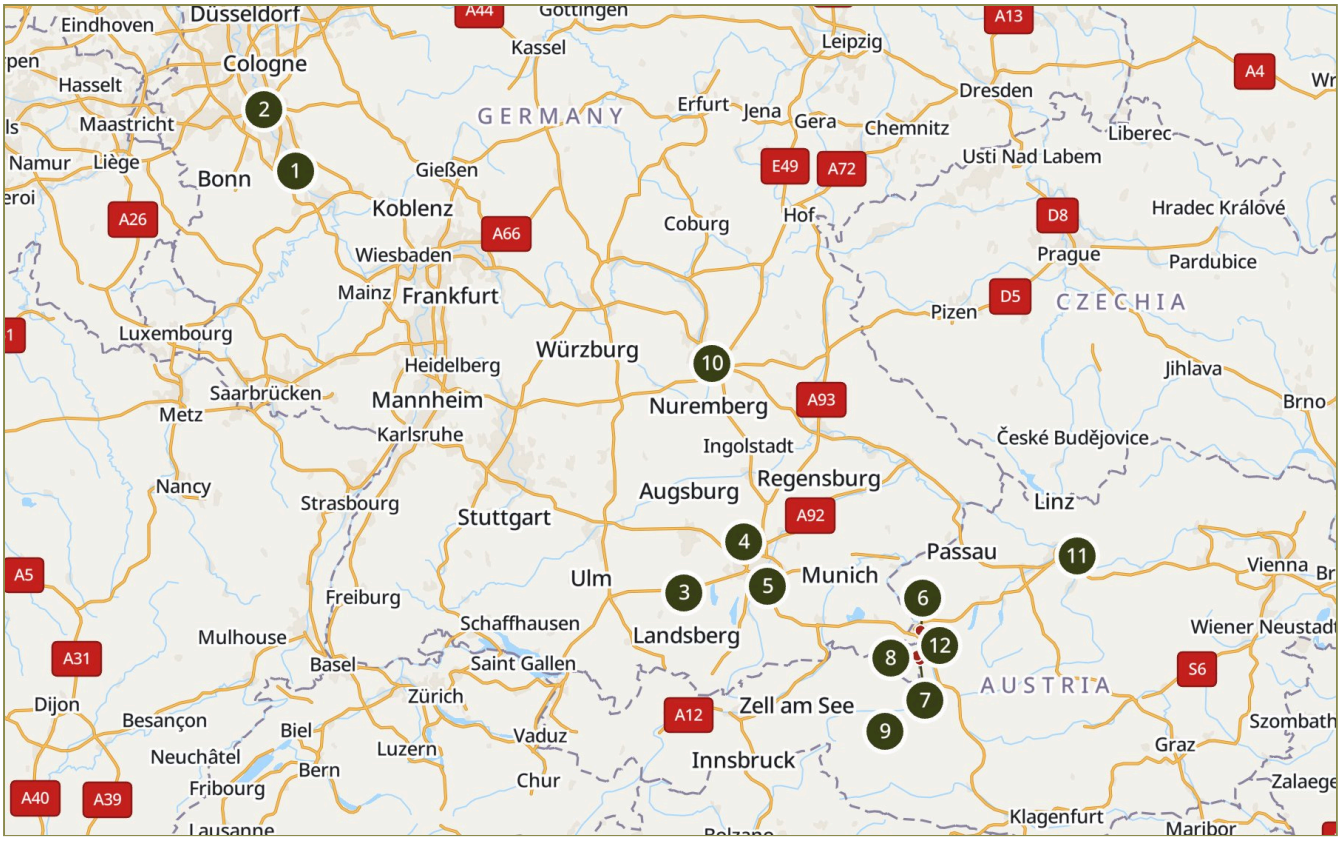
HIGH Austria · the camps · 5 May 1945

The Austrian main camp, liberated the day Easy reached Berchtesgaden.

What you can see: 2 h east of Zell am See.

GPS 48.25700, 14.50100

MUSEUMS



1 Peace Museum — Bridge at Remagen
2 NS Documentation Centre (EL-DE Haus)
3 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII
4 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial
5 Munich Documentation Centre
6 Dokumentation Obersalzberg
7 Kehlsteinhaus — Eagle's Nest
8 Salzbergwerk Berchtesgaden
9 Kaprun dams — Erlebniswelt Strom
10 Nuremberg Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld
11 Mauthausen Memorial
12 Salzburg — Festung & old town

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors

The museums worth your time on this part of the route. Check opening days before you travel.

1 Peace Museum — Bridge at Remagen

Remagen · Day 1 · 1 hr

The Rhine crossing of 7 March 1945, in the surviving bridge towers.

GPS 50.57900, 7.24250

2 NS Documentation Centre (EL-DE Haus)

Cologne · Day 1 · 1 hr

Gestapo prison and the story of Cologne under the Nazis; ten minutes from the cathedral.

GPS 50.93940, 6.95200

3 European Holocaust Memorial — Kaufering VII

Landsberg am Lech · Day 2 · 1 hr

The surviving Kaufering camp; earth huts and memorial stones.

GPS 48.03048, 10.85248

4 Dachau Concentration Camp Memorial

Dachau · Day 2 · 2.5 hr

The first camp; the Kaufering camps were its sub-camps.

GPS 48.26980, 11.46830

5 Munich Documentation Centre

Munich · Day 3 · 1.5 hr

How Munich made the Nazi movement; on the site of the Brown House.

GPS 48.14660, 11.56800

6 Dokumentation Obersalzberg

Berchtesgaden · Day 3 · 2 hr

Hitler's mountain, the bunkers and May 1945. Rebuilt 2023.

GPS 47.63130, 13.04180

7 Kehlsteinhaus — Eagle's Nest

Berchtesgaden · Day 4 · 2 hr

The tea-house, the lift, the terrace. Bus access mid-May to Oct.

GPS 47.61140, 13.04180

8 Salzbergwerk Berchtesgaden

Berchtesgaden · Extra · 1.5 hr

The salt mine 506th men toured as tourists in May 1945. (Göring's looted art was found in Obersalzberg shelters, trains and caches — the famous salt-mine repository was Altaussee in Austria, not here.)

GPS 47.63797, 13.01800

9 Kaprun dams — Erlebniswelt Strom

Kaprun · Day 5 · 2 hr

The Nazi-era hydro project and its forced labourers; the post-war dams.

GPS 47.16250, 12.71750

10 Nuremberg Documentation Centre & Zeppelinfeld

Nuremberg · Extra · 2 hr

The rally grounds and the museum of the party rallies; the courtroom of the 1945–46 trials is across town.

GPS 49.43350, 11.11080

11 Mauthausen Memorial

Mauthausen, Austria · Extra · 2.5 hr

The Austrian main camp, liberated by the US 11th Armored on 5 May 1945 — the same day Easy reached Berchtesgaden.

GPS 48.25700, 14.50100

12 Salzburg — Festung & old town

Salzburg · Extra · half day

The 506th's nearest city in the summer of 1945; passes and the opera festival's first post-war season in August 1945.

GPS 47.79500, 13.04700

PEOPLE

THE COMPANY'S WAR IN BRIEF

Easy Company was one of the first American rifle companies built entirely from paratrooper volunteers. It fought from the night drop into Normandy to the end of the war in the Alps, and it lost 48 men killed along the way (the Winters/Ambrose count; other rosters give 49).

Toccoa, 1942–43. Company E of the 506th Parachute Infantry was formed at Camp Toccoa, Georgia, in summer 1942 under 1st Lt. Herbert Sobel, who was soon promoted captain. Most of its men came straight from civilian life. They ran Currahee Mountain — "three miles up, three miles down" — until only the toughest were left, then trained at Benning, Mackall and Bragg before sailing for England in September 1943.

England, 1943–44. The company trained at Aldbourne, Wiltshire. Sobel's clash with his platoon leader Richard Winters led almost every sergeant to hand in his stripes. Sobel was moved out and 1st Lt. Thomas Meehan took command.

Normandy, June–July 1944. Easy jumped behind Utah Beach on the night of 5–6 June. Meehan's plane was shot down and everyone aboard was killed, so Winters took command. That morning he led about a dozen men against the guns at Brécourt Manor. Easy then fought at Carentan and Bloody Gulch and sailed back to England in July.

Holland, September–November 1944. Easy jumped into Holland on 17 September for Market Garden. It entered Eindhoven, was thrown back at Nuenen, and spent weeks on "the Island" between the rivers. On 5 October Winters led the crossroads attack and was then promoted to battalion executive officer. The company helped rescue about 138 Allied soldiers, mostly British airborne troops, in Operation Pegasus.

Bastogne, December 1944–January 1945. Rushed to the Ardennes with too little winter clothing and ammunition, Easy held the edge of the Bois Jacques above Foy. Shelling cost the company Toye's and Guarnere's legs and the lives of Muck and Penkala. On 13 January Lt. Ronald Speirs took over in the middle of the attack on Foy, and the company went on to Noville and Rachamps.

Haguenau and Germany, 1945. Easy held the Moder river in Alsace in February 1945. It then watched the Ruhr pocket from the Rhine and moved into Bavaria, where on 28–29 April it entered a Kaufering sub-camp near Landsberg (probably Kaufering IV). On 5 May it reached Berchtesgaden and the Obersalzberg.

Austria and home, 1945. After Germany surrendered, Easy occupied Zell am See and Kaprun in Austria. It moved to France in the summer to train for Japan, but the war ended first. The 101st Airborne was inactivated on 30 November 1945.

THE OFFICERS

Richard D. Winters "Dick" — Platoon leader, company commander, then battalion commander. Born 21 Jan 1918, New Holland, Pennsylvania · died 2 Jan 2011, Campbelltown, Pennsylvania

An economics graduate of Franklin & Marshall College, Winters joined Easy at Toccoa in 1942 as a platoon leader. When Lt. Meehan was killed on D-Day he took command, and that morning led about a dozen men against the four guns at Brécourt Manor. He was recommended for the Medal of Honor and received the Distinguished Service Cross. He was wounded at Carentan and led the crossroads attack in Holland on 5 October 1944, then became battalion executive officer and later its commander, ending the war as a major. Calm, sober and devout, he was the man Easy trusted most.

Decorations: Distinguished Service Cross — leading the attack on the guns at Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944 (he had been recommended for the Medal of Honor); Bronze Star — reason not recorded (some records show a second); Purple Heart — wounded in the leg at Carentan, June 1944.

After the war: Worked for the Nixon family firm, then ran his own animal-feed business in Hershey. Wrote a memoir with Col. Cole Kingseed (2006).

Lewis Nixon III “Nix” — Battalion intelligence officer, Winters' closest friend. Born 30 Sep 1918, New York City · died 11 Jan 1995, Los Angeles

The wealthy, Yale-educated son of an industrial family, Nixon was never in Easy itself but served on 2nd Battalion staff beside it from Toccoa onward. He jumped into Normandy and Holland, where a bullet grazed his forehead. In March 1945 he jumped with the 17th Airborne in Operation Varsity; his plane was hit and only four men got out. He drank heavily during the war, and Winters stood by him throughout.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded (some sources say two); Parachute wings with three combat-jump stars — Normandy, Holland and Operation Varsity, a rare set.

After the war: Brought Winters into the family business; later remarried and gave up drinking.

Herbert M. Sobel — Easy's first commander. Born 26 Jan 1912, Chicago · died 30 Sep 1987, Waukegan, Illinois

Sobel built Easy at Toccoa and drove it relentlessly: extra runs, harsh punishments, cancelled passes. His men found him petty and doubted his judgement in the field. When he court-martialled Winters in England, nearly every sergeant offered to give up his stripes, and he was moved out in early 1944. He went on to run a parachute school and later served as the regiment's supply officer, and he jumped on D-Day. Several veterans later credited him with making Easy as tough as it was.

Decorations: Bronze Star — no citation survives; one account links it to D-Day, when he and four men knocked out a German machine-gun nest with grenades.

After the war: Worked in Chicago as a credit manager; spent his last years in a veterans' home.

Thomas Meehan III — Company commander, Feb–June 1944. Born 8 Jul 1921, Philadelphia · killed in action 6 Jun 1944, near Beuzeville-au-Plain, Normandy

A Philadelphia art student who transferred to Easy from B Company, Meehan took command after Sobel left. On D-Day he led the company headquarters in C-47 "Chalk 66". The plane was hit by flak and crashed near Beuzeville-au-Plain; everyone aboard was killed, including 1st Sgt. William Evans. Easy did not learn his fate until long after. The wreck was found in the early 1950s and reportedly excavated in 1989; a memorial now marks the site.

Ronald C. Speirs “Sparky” — Easy's longest-serving commander, Jan 1945 to the end. Born 20 Apr 1920, Edinburgh, Scotland · died 11 Apr 2007, Montana

Brought up in Boston, Speirs fought in Normandy with D Company, including at Brécourt, and was wounded. He won the Silver Star in Holland for a solo patrol across the Lower Rhine. On 13 January 1945, in the attack on Foy, Winters sent him to take over Easy mid-battle; he famously ran through the German-held village to reach I Company and back. He led Easy through Haguenau, Germany and Austria. Stories that he shot prisoners were never confirmed.

Decorations: Silver Star — swam the Lower Rhine (Neder Rijn) alone near Randwijk to scout German positions and came back with a captured boat, 10 October 1944, wounded on the way back; Bronze Star — reason not recorded (number not confirmed); Purple Heart with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — wounded in Normandy, June 1944, and in Holland, 10 October 1944; Legion of Merit — after the war, for service from October 1961 to March 1964, a period that included Laos.

After the war: Stayed in the Army — Korea, US governor of Spandau Prison in Berlin, Laos; retired a lieutenant colonel.

Lynn Compton “Buck” — Platoon leader. Born 31 Dec 1921, Los Angeles · died 25 Feb 2012, Burlington, Washington

A UCLA catcher and Rose Bowl footballer, Compton won the Silver Star at Brécourt Manor. He was shot through the buttocks in Holland and came back to lead his platoon at Bastogne. After watching his friends Toye and Guarnere lose their legs in January 1945, he was evacuated with severe trench foot.

Decorations: Silver Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944; Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — shot through the buttocks in Holland, September 1944.

After the war: Police detective, then prosecutor who led the case against Robert Kennedy's assassin, Sirhan Sirhan (1969); California appeals court judge 1970–90.

Harry F. Welsh “Welshy” — Platoon leader, later executive officer. Born 27 Sep 1918, Pennsylvania · died 21 Jan 1995, Wilkes-Barre, Pennsylvania

A former enlisted paratrooper who reportedly won and lost his sergeant's stripes several times for fighting, Welsh went to officer school and joined Easy. He led 1st Platoon into Carentan and was wounded at Bastogne at Christmas 1944, returning in 1945. He was Winters' closest friend in the company.

Decorations: Bronze Star with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — reasons not recorded; Purple Heart with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — one for the mortar wound at Bastogne, Christmas 1944; the other wound is not recorded.

After the war: Married Kitty Grogan, a friend of Winters, in a wedding dress made from parachute silk; taught at GAR and Coughlin high schools in Wilkes-Barre, then was Director of Pupil Services for the Wilkes-Barre Area School District until 1983.

Frederick Heyliger “Moose” — Company commander, Oct 1944. Born 23 Jun 1916, Acton, Massachusetts · died 3 Nov 2001, Concord, Massachusetts

A big, well-liked former mortar platoon leader, Heyliger took command of Easy when Winters moved up in October 1944. He led the company in Operation Pegasus, the night rescue across the Rhine of about 138 Allied soldiers, mostly British, and received the British Military Cross. On 31 October he was badly wounded by one of his own sentries while checking the line with Winters, and he did not return.

Decorations: British Military Cross — leading Operation Pegasus, the rescue of about 138 Allied evaders, mostly British, night of 22–23 October 1944; Bronze Star — citation not found; Purple Heart — shot by his own sentry on the Island, 31 October 1944.

After the war: Studied horticulture at the University of Massachusetts.

Norman S. Dike Jr. “Foxhole Norman” — Company commander, Nov 1944 – 13 Jan 1945. Born 19 May 1918, Brooklyn, New York · died 23 Jun 1989, Rolle, Switzerland

A Brown graduate and Yale law student, Dike came from regimental staff to command Easy after Heyliger. The men felt he was rarely seen on the line, hence the nickname, yet he earned two Bronze Stars, one for carrying wounded men to safety at Bastogne. During the attack on Foy on 13 January 1945 the advance stalled and Winters replaced him with Speirs. Why it stalled is disputed (see the notes at the end).

Decorations: Bronze Star — rallying scattered paratroopers to hold the road junction at Uden, Holland, while surrounded, 23–25 September 1944; Bronze Star (second award) — carrying three wounded men out of an exposed position under fire at Bastogne, 3 January 1945; Purple Heart with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — one reportedly for a shoulder wound at Foy, 13 January 1945.

After the war: Yale law degree, work in Japan and for the CIA, then a legal and business career; lived in Switzerland from 1960.

THE SERGEANTS

C. Carwood Lipton “Lip” — First sergeant, later lieutenant. Born 30 Jan 1920, Huntington, West Virginia · died 16 Dec 2001, North Carolina

His father was killed and his mother paralysed in a car crash when he was ten. Lipton enlisted in 1942 and was one of Easy's first privates. He fought at Brécourt Manor, was wounded at Carentan, and became first sergeant — the man who held the company together at Bastogne while its officers failed or fell. After Foy he was commissioned a lieutenant in the field, and he served through Germany and Austria.

Decorations: Bronze Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944, where he climbed a tree to fire into the German position (some records show a second Bronze Star); Purple Heart — shell fragments to the face and groin at Carentan, June 1944; his headstone records two more, for three in all.

After the war: Engineering degree from Marshall; a long career with the glassmaker Owens-Illinois.

William Guarnere “Wild Bill” — 2nd Platoon sergeant. Born 28 Apr 1923, South Philadelphia · died 8 Mar 2014, Philadelphia

The youngest of ten in an Italian-American family, Guarnere built Sherman tanks before enlisting. He jumped into Normandy knowing his brother had just been killed in Italy, and fought with fury at Brécourt Manor, earning the Silver Star. Shot in the leg in Holland, he slipped out of hospital to rejoin the company. On 3 January 1945 near Foy he lost a leg to shellfire while helping the wounded Joe Toye.

Decorations: Silver Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944; Bronze Star with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — reasons not recorded; Purple Heart (two) — a sniper's bullet in the leg on the Island, October 1944, and the loss of his leg near Foy, 3 January 1945.

After the war: Veterans' advocate; co-wrote Brothers in Battle, Best of Friends (2007) with Babe Heffron. Statues of him stand in Pennsylvania.

Donald G. Malarkey — Mortar sergeant. Born 31 Jul 1921, Astoria, Oregon · died 30 Sep 2017, Salem, Oregon

A University of Oregon student from the Columbia River coast, Malarkey fought at Brécourt and then in every Easy campaign. He is said to have spent more continuous time on the line than anyone in the company without being seriously wounded. The death of his close friends Skip Muck and Alex Penkala at Bastogne stayed with him all his life.

Decorations: Bronze Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944; a second Bronze Star, reason not recorded; Purple Heart — the wound is not recorded; French Legion of Honour — awarded in 2009 as a surviving veteran of the liberation of France.

After the war: County commissioner in Oregon; wrote Easy Company Soldier (2008).

Joseph Toye “Joe” — Squad leader. Born 14 Mar 1919, Hughestown, Pennsylvania · died 3 Sep 1995, Reading, Pennsylvania

A coal miner's son who left school to work in the mines, Toye was known as one of the toughest men in the company. He fought at Brécourt, was wounded in Holland and again at Bastogne, and on 3 January 1945 lost his right leg to shellfire in the Bois Jacques. He had more wounds than almost anyone in Easy.

Decorations: Bronze Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944; Purple Hearts — three or four (sources differ; a local marker calls it the most in Easy): shellfire in Holland, autumn 1944; wounds at Bastogne; and the loss of his leg near Foy, 3 January 1945.

After the war: Worked at the Grace iron mine for Bethlehem Steel. Winters gave his eulogy.

Floyd Talbert “Tab” — Squad leader, briefly first sergeant. Born 26 Aug 1923, Howard County, Indiana · died Oct 1982, Shasta Lake, California

Talbert was wounded in Normandy, reportedly by an Easy man who mistook him in the dark for a German. He came back to serve in Holland and at Bastogne and was made first sergeant, a job he later gave up to return to his men. Winters rated him among the finest soldiers in the company.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — most likely for the bayonet wound in Normandy, June 1944.

After the war: Worked in industry and farming; lost touch with Easy until a reunion in 1981.

Denver Randleman “Bull” — Squad leader. Born 20 Nov 1920, Rector, Arkansas · died 26 Jun 2003

A big, quiet Arkansan and former foundry worker, Randleman fought in Normandy and at Carentan. At Nuenen in Holland in September 1944 he was wounded and cut off; he hid in a barn, killed a German soldier who found him, and rejoined the company the next day. He went on through Bastogne, Foy and Haguenau.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — shoulder wound from a tank shell in Holland, September 1944, the fight in which he hid in the barn.

After the war: Service manager for a Caterpillar dealer, then construction superintendent in Louisiana.

Warren Muck “Skip” — Sergeant, mortar squad. Born 31 Jan 1922, Tonawanda, New York · killed in action 10 Jan 1945, Bois Jacques, near Foy, Belgium

A cheerful young man from upstate New York and Malarkey's closest friend, Muck jumped into Normandy and Holland. On 10 January 1945 a shell struck the foxhole he shared with Pvt. Alex Penkala in the Bois Jacques, killing both. Both are buried in the Luxembourg American Cemetery at Hamm.

Decorations: Bronze Star with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — reasons not recorded; Purple Heart (posthumous) — killed in the Bois Jacques, 10 January 1945.

Darrell Powers “Shifty” — Rifleman and marksman, later staff sergeant. Born 13 Mar 1923, Clinchco, Virginia · died 17 Jun 2009, Bristol, Tennessee

Raised hunting in the Appalachian hills, Powers was one of Easy's best shots. At Bastogne he noticed a "tree that wasn't there yesterday" — a hidden German position — and at Foy he killed a sniper. He was never wounded in combat, but after winning the lottery for a trip home in 1945 he was badly hurt when his truck crashed on the way.

Decorations: Bronze Star with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — reasons not recorded.

After the war: Machinist, then more than 20 years with Clinchfield Coal; married to Dorothy for about 60 years.

THE MEN

Edward Heffron “Babe” — Machine gunner. Born 16 May 1923, South Philadelphia · died 1 Dec 2013, Stratford, New Jersey

A shipyard worker from an Irish Catholic family, Heffron joined Easy as a replacement in England after Normandy. He jumped into Holland and fought at Bastogne, where in late December 1944 he was pinned down trying to reach his dying friend John Julian. He was at a Kaufering sub-camp and in Berchtesgaden in 1945. He and Bill Guarnere, from the same neighbourhood, stayed best friends for life.

Decorations: Bronze Star — Bastogne, winter 1944–45 (the action is not recorded); Purple Heart — the wound is not recorded.

After the war: Worked at a whiskey distillery and then on the Philadelphia docks; co-wrote Brothers in Battle, Best of Friends (2007).

George Luz — Company radio operator. Born 17 Jun 1921, Fall River, Massachusetts · died 15 Oct 1998, West Warwick, Rhode Island

The company's joker, famous for his impressions of officers, Luz carried Easy's radio from Normandy through Holland, Bastogne and into Germany and Austria. His humour kept men going in the worst moments of the siege.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — the wound is not recorded.

After the war: Maintenance work in Rhode Island; killed in an industrial accident. About 1,600 people came to his funeral.

David Kenyon Webster — Rifleman and writer. Born 2 Jun 1922, New York City · lost at sea 9 Sep 1961, off Santa Monica, California

A Harvard English student who volunteered for the paratroopers, Webster jumped on D-Day with battalion headquarters and joined Easy afterwards. He was shot in the leg on the Island in Holland on 5 October 1944 and rejoined at Haguenau. His clear, often critical writing about the war made him the company's chronicler, and Ambrose drew heavily on it.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — a shell-fragment wound in Normandy, June 1944, and a machine-gun bullet through the leg on the Island, October 1944.

After the war: Journalist. He vanished while sailing alone off Santa Monica in 1961; his memoir Parachute Infantry was published in 1994.

Eugene Roe “Doc” — Medic. Born 17 Oct 1921 or 1922, Bayou Chêne, Louisiana · died 30 Dec 1998, Baton Rouge, Louisiana

A Cajun from St. Martin Parish, Roe was the battalion medic attached to Easy from Normandy to the end of the war. At Bastogne he worked in the snow and cold with almost no supplies, going from foxhole to foxhole under shellfire. His officer recommended him for the Silver Star, which he never received.

Decorations: Bronze Star with oak leaf cluster (two awards) — reasons not recorded; Combat Medical Badge.

After the war: Construction contractor in Louisiana.

Joseph Liebgott — Rifleman and German interpreter. Born 17 May 1915, Michigan · died 28 Jun 1992, San Bernardino, California

The son of German-speaking immigrants, Liebgott grew up in the San Francisco Bay Area and worked as a barber. He fought at Brécourt and Carentan, was wounded twice on the Island in Holland, and fought at Bastogne. In 1945 his German made him Easy's interpreter, including at a Kaufering sub-camp. Many of his comrades assumed he was Jewish; his family says he was not.

Decorations: Bronze Star — Brécourt Manor, 6 June 1944.

After the war: Barber in the Bay Area; father of eight.

Albert Blithe — Rifleman. Born 25 Jun 1923, Philadelphia · died 17 Dec 1967, Wiesbaden, West Germany

Blithe jumped into Normandy and, around Carentan, suffered a brief stress-induced blindness. He was then shot by a sniper in the collarbone and shoulder — his Purple Heart is dated 25 June 1944, his 21st birthday — and did not return to Easy. Early accounts said he died of his wounds in 1948; that is wrong.

Decorations: Purple Heart — sniper's bullet in the shoulder near Carentan, 25 June 1944.

After the war: Stayed in the Army; served in Korea with the 187th Airborne, earning a Silver Star, and died on active duty as a master sergeant. Buried at Arlington.

Edward D. Shames — Platoon leader. Born 13 Jun 1922, Norfolk, Virginia · died 3 Dec 2021, Virginia

The son of Jewish immigrants, Shames joined as an I Company paratrooper, became a 3rd Battalion operations sergeant, and received a battlefield commission in Normandy on his 22nd birthday. He joined Easy as a platoon leader, volunteered for the Pegasus rescue, and fought at Bastogne and Foy, where he helped knock out a German tank with a bazooka. At Berchtesgaden in May 1945 he took cognac labelled for Hitler's own use.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — a leg wound (sources give one to three awards).

After the war: Middle East specialist at the National Security Agency; he used the cognac for his son's Bar Mitzvah. He was the last surviving Easy officer.

Walter Gordon “Smokey” — Machine gunner. Born 15 Apr 1920 or 1921, Jackson, Mississippi · died 19 Apr 1997, Mississippi

A college student turned down by the Marines and Navy, Gordon was with Easy from Toccoa. He jumped into Normandy and Holland. On Christmas Eve 1944 at Bastogne a sniper's bullet passed through both shoulders and grazed his spine, paralysing him for a time; he never returned to combat.

Decorations: Bronze Star — reason not recorded; Purple Heart — for his wounds at Carentan (13 June 1944) and Bastogne (24 December 1944); records show one award.

After the war: Law degree, then a career as an oil and gas lease broker in Louisiana; organised Easy Company reunions from 1946.

ABOUT THE DECORATIONS

The most decorated single action was Brécourt Manor on D-Day: Winters received the Distinguished Service Cross; Compton, Guarnere and Lt. Lorraine the Silver Star; and Lipton, Malarkey, Toye, Liebgott and several others the Bronze Star.

"Reason not recorded" means no citation survives online. After the war, in 1947, the Army gave a Bronze Star to every soldier who had earned the Combat Infantryman Badge (or the Combat Medical Badge, for medics). That is the likely reason for many of these Bronze Stars, but it is not confirmed for any one man.

Every man here also shared the unit awards, so they are not repeated on each card: the Presidential Unit Citation for Normandy and again for Bastogne, the Dutch Orange Lanyard for Holland, the Belgian Fourragère, and the French Croix de Guerre with palm for Normandy.

Oak leaf cluster = a second (or further) award of the same medal.

WHERE THE SOURCES DISAGREE

These bios follow the best-supported version.

Dike
: Winters, Lipton and most witnesses say he froze at Foy; Clancy Lyall later said he had been hit in the shoulder. This guide says only that the advance stalled.

Speirs
: Stories that he shot German prisoners in Normandy; no eyewitness confirms them.

Sobel
: Remembered as a petty tyrant, but several veterans credit him with making Easy tough; the TV drama leaves out his D-Day jump.

Blithe

Early books and the TV drama said he died of his wounds in 1948 — he died in 1967; the wound was the collarbone/shoulder, not the neck.

Liebgott
Often shown as Jewish; his family says he was not.

Compton
The TV drama showed him as shell-shocked; he blamed trench foot and exhaustion.

Powers
The first edition of Ambrose said he refused a patrol at Bastogne; both he and Shames denied it and it was removed.

Shames
Whether he was among the first into the Eagle's Nest, and whether the cognac came from there or from Hitler's quarters below.

Talbert
Ambrose describes a troubled post-war life; his family disputes it.

Gordon
His first wound: Carentan (June 1944) or near Eindhoven (Holland).

Guarnere
Born 1922 or 1923; right or left leg lost.

Welsh
Wounded Christmas Eve or Christmas Day 1944; born in Audenried or Wilkes-Barre.

Winters
Recommended for the Medal of Honor for Brécourt; received the Distinguished Service Cross instead.

WORDS TO KNOW

E Company — "Easy" Company — about 140 men of the 506th Parachute Infantry Regiment

PIR — Parachute Infantry Regiment — about 2,000 paratroopers

101st — the 101st Airborne Division, "Screaming Eagles"

CP — command post — where the officers ran the fight

DZ — drop zone — the field the paratroopers were meant to land in

Stick — the 15–18 men who jumped from one plane

C-47 — the twin-engine transport plane that carried them

XO — executive officer — the second-in-command

NCO — sergeants and corporals

Flak — anti-aircraft fire

LZ — landing zone

GIR — Glider Infantry Regiment

BAR — automatic rifle

MG — machine gun

HQ — headquarters

OP — lookout post

Fallschirmjäger — German paratroopers

CREDITS

Sources for the company’s origins:
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Currahee Military Museum, Toccoa
Book: Stephen E. Ambrose's 1992 history of Easy Company, chapters 1–4.

Sources: Stephen Ambrose’s history of the company; Winters’ and Webster’s memoirs; TracesOfWar, Hall of Valor, Wikipedia, Find a Grave and obituaries.

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A free DZ Charlie field guide · dzcharlie.com. The phone guide adds the battle story as audio, the weapons of the company, the chain of command and a personal diary of your tour.